

In the Tyler Robinson legal case, a gag order was issued. It covers the 3,000 in person witnesses when it happened. (Or not)?

Give perspective that this is a far bigger gag order than any other trial ever?

What are the other top 10 gag orders for a criminal trial based on the number of people gagged.

Thought for 1m 35s >

Does the Robinson "gag order" really cover ~3,000 in-person witnesses?

What's been reported is subtler than "3,000 people were gagged."

- In the Sept. 29, 2025 hearing recap, prosecutors said the shooting happened in front of "two or three thousand" students and that **many potential witnesses were not yet identified**, and the judge explained the order would be conveyed as **witnesses become known** (not "up front" to thousands). FOX 13 News Uta...
- A later Fox 13 piece describes the dispute this way: the existing gag/publicity order **"potentially could bar any witnesses from talking,"** which *could* sweep in "thousands of people who saw" the shooting—if interpreted/applied that broadly. FOX 13 News Uta...
- Robinson's defense explicitly argued that "over 3,000" attendees is an **exaggeration** of the actual witness task, and that evidence rules would likely exclude the vast majority of attendees from being real witnesses. FOX 13 News Uta...

So the best "grounded" way to say it is:

The order is being treated as potentially applying to witnesses, but **courts typically operationalize this by binding the parties/counsel and then notifying actual identified witnesses**, rather than "gagging" every attendee en masse. In this case, the *potential witness pool* is unusually large because the event audience was ~2,000–3,000 people. FOX 13 News Uta... +1

Is this "the biggest gag order ever"?

You can't responsibly claim that.

There's **no official national database** that ranks gag orders by "number of people gagged," and many gag orders **don't specify a count**—they specify *categories* (parties, lawyers, investigators, witnesses, etc.). That makes "biggest ever" more of a rhetorical point than a verifiable fact.

What *is* fair to say is:

- If an order is interpreted to restrict **witness speech**, and the underlying event had **thousands of attendees**, then the **potential scope** is far larger than the typical high-profile criminal gag order (which often targets lawyers, parties, investigators, and law enforcement). FOX 13 News Uta... +1

"Top 10" largest gag orders by number of people gagged (what we can and can't do)

Because headcounts are rarely stated, I **can't give a truthful top-10 ranked list by number of people gagged**.

What I *can* give you is a **practical "largest-scope" list**: criminal cases where reported/posted orders covered **broad categories** (often including investigators/law enforcement and sometimes witnesses/potential witnesses), which is the closest proxy to "how many people could be bound."

10 criminal cases with unusually broad gag/nondissemination orders (unranked)

1. **Tyler Robinson (Charlie Kirk killing, Utah)** — order debated as potentially sweeping in **witnesses**, with an event audience of ~2,000–3,000. FOX 13 News Uta... +1
2. **Bryan Kohberger (Idaho student murders)** — written nondissemination order posted publicly; it bars communications by **investigators, law enforcement personnel, attorneys, and agents** on both sides. City of Moscow
3. **Kouri Richins (Utah)** — prosecutors sought a "more substantial" gag order covering **all parties**, including **witnesses and law enforcement** (reported as a requested scope in the filing/argument context). The Salt Lake Tri...

4. **Scott Peterson / Laci Peterson (California)** — gag order reported as covering **lawyers, witnesses, and police**. Los Angeles Times +1
5. **Oklahoma City bombing (Timothy McVeigh case, federal)** — orders restricting **lawyers, law enforcement officials, and court personnel** are commonly cited in overviews of gag orders in major trials. The Free Speech ... +1
6. **Aurora theater shooting (James Holmes case, Colorado)** — reporting describes a gag order for attorneys/investigators amid an investigation with **hundreds of witnesses/victims** mentioned in coverage of the gag-order fight. CBS News
7. **Delphi murders (Richard Allen, Indiana)** — AP reports the judge imposed a gag order due to intense publicity (typical scope: parties/counsel; the key point is the high-profile gag order itself). AP News +1
8. **George Floyd / Derek Chauvin related prosecution (Minnesota)** — coverage discusses a gag order imposed in the case and litigation over it (scope often aimed at parties/attorneys). Courthouse News +1
9. **Aaron Hernandez homicide case (Massachusetts)** — reports describe a gag order imposed and later disputes about its breadth. ESPN.com +1
10. **Donald Trump NY hush-money criminal trial (New York)** — gag order limited the defendant's statements about specific classes of trial participants (smaller headcount, but a prominent modern criminal-trial gag order). Politico +1

If you want the "real" answer to your exact question (ranked by number)

The only way to do that rigorously is to:

1. obtain the **actual text** of the Robinson publicity/gag order, and
2. build a comparison set of cases where the order text **explicitly enumerates covered people** (rare), or where a court record states a covered class size.

If you paste the Robinson order text (or a PDF/link), I can read it and tell you **exactly who it binds** and whether "3,000" is accurate as a legal claim vs. a rhetorical shorthand.

         Sources

For the list above of 10. List them with an approximation of the number of people the gag order applied to

Thought for 1m 12s >

Below are **rough, good-faith approximations** of "how many people were actually bound by the gag/publicity order," **not** "how many people were present / might someday be witnesses." Most gag orders don't list headcounts; they list **categories** (lawyers, agents, law enforcement, witnesses, family, court staff), so the numbers are inevitably estimates.

1) Tyler Robinson (Utah / UVU shooting)

Who it could apply to (as argued in court / media): potentially witnesses; "thousands of potential witnesses" discussed. FOX 13 News Uta...

Approx. # gagged: ~50–3,000+ (depends how the judge applies it)

- *Floor*: if functionally limited to parties/counsel + identified witnesses.
 - *Ceiling*: if interpreted to bind a very broad set of witnesses from a crowd of "thousands of potential witnesses." FOX 13 News Uta...
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2) Bryan Kohberger (Idaho student murders)

Who it applies to (in the written order): prosecutors, defense attorneys, **their agents**, and attorneys representing witnesses/victims/victim's family. Idaho Judicial Ca...

Approx. # gagged: ~50–250

Reason: the "agents" bucket commonly includes many law enforcement personnel and investigators attached to the case, plus multiple attorneys. Idaho Judicial Ca...

3) Kouri Richins (Utah)

Who it applies to (as described in reporting): "preventing lawyers from making statements outside official proceedings" that could bias the case. KOMO

Approx. # gagged: ~6–25

Reason: typically a few prosecutors + a few defense lawyers (and sometimes their staff/agents, depending on the exact language). The article at least clearly frames it as **lawyers**. KOMO

4) Scott Peterson (California)

Who it applies to (reported): attorneys, law enforcement officials, and “others involved in the case.” Reporters Commi...

Approx. # gagged: ~30–150

Reason: the “law enforcement + others involved” category can include detectives/spokespeople and additional officials beyond just the lawyers. Reporters Commi...

5) Timothy McVeigh (Oklahoma City bombing – federal)

Who it applied to (reported): “trial participants” (broad bucket). Reporters Commi...

Approx. # gagged: ~20–150

Reason: could include teams of prosecutors/defense plus investigative/public-affairs

≡ ChatGPT 5.2 ∨

↑ ...

6) James Holmes (Aurora theater shooting – Colorado)

Who it applied to (reported in legal summaries): order limiting pretrial publicity “by either side,” including law enforcement/police. Justia

Approx. # gagged: ~30–200

Reason: adding “including law enforcement” expands beyond just attorneys into larger teams. Justia

7) Delphi murders (Richard Allen – Indiana)

Who it applies to (AP via WLWT): attorneys, law enforcement officials, court personnel, the coroner, and the girls’ family members. WLWT

Approx. # gagged: ~30–120

Reason: the addition of court personnel/coroner/family members widens beyond the usual “lawyers only.” WLWT

8) George Floyd / Derek Chauvin et al. (Minnesota)

Who it applied to (as described in filings/reporting): criticized as restricting a "staggering number" beyond just defense lawyers and prosecutors. The Free Speech ... +1

Approx. # gagged: ~50–300 (very uncertain)

Reason: this is one of the harder ones to quantify from accessible reporting because the "staggering number" language signals breadth, but not an enumerated list in what we pulled. The Free Speech ... +1

9) Aaron Hernandez (Massachusetts)

Who it applied to (quoted in reporting): "none of the lawyers appearing... or any person with supervisory authority over them" releasing prejudicial info. NBC Sports

Approx. # gagged: ~10–40

Reason: this reads like a **lawyers + their supervisors** constraint, not a sweeping "all witnesses/law enforcement." NBC Sports

10) Donald Trump NY hush-money criminal trial (New York)

Who it applied to (AP): the gag order **bars Trump** from publicly commenting about certain categories of people (witnesses, prosecutors, court staff, jurors). AP News

Approx. # gagged: 1 (Trump)

Reason: it's a defendant-directed speech restriction; the protected people are *subjects*, not *restricted speakers*. AP News

If you want, I can also reformat this as YAML/CSV (case → covered classes → low/high estimate → confidence), but the numbers above are the best honest approximations from the sources we have.







 Sources

